

Padea Competition

June 2nd, 2026

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Finals Brief

Congratulations on making it to the final round. The goal for your final submission is to improve your solution using the feedback and information from your heats presentation. No solution was close to perfect. You should consider the following...

First, many of you did not accurately define the problem. I have put the most important paragraph in the task sheet below again. I encourage you to really think about what each sentence is asking from you and if the requirements of your solution match. There are no tricks here.

Students often tell us the selected meals don't match their taste preferences. Food quality also tends to decline over time with each caterer. Ordering meals is tedious for the program coordinator – and will become a bottleneck for the business.

Your task: solve the problem from order to delivery.

Second, those of you who did accurately define the problem, solved it in a less-than-optimal way. I think this is because many of you are falsely constraining yourselves. You are all high achievers; in high school and university you have been trained to optimise within fixed resources and a marking rubric. The real world does not work like that.

Because the task was deliberately vague, many of you self-imposed constraints that did not exist. The Operations Engineer owns the system and can change anything in it (within reason). This is your opportunity to think outside of the box without being punished for it. Remember, you are trying to make the smartest, simplest, fastest, most automated solution that meets your defined requirements.

Third, almost all of you identified and handled exclusions, absences, opt-outs, dietarys, and MOQs – these are the obvious operating parameters. But there are an infinite number of operating parameters in a system... and you will never handle them all.

An edge case lives at the boundary of what your system can handle; anything past this boundary is an unhandled case. You can spend forever dragging unhandled cases inside the boundary one at a time, or you can focus on the boundary itself – what your system does when it meets something it was not built for. Only one of those scales.

Think clearly about what a human, an AI and code are each best at, and what should own which decisions. To get a model’s full capabilities, you need to give it as much context as you would give an employee.

Fourth, this round is where you display your taste. Would Steve Jobs describe your solution as “the best thing ever” or “the biggest piece of shit he's ever seen?”

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Deliverables

1. Build Artifact

Share what you built – GitHub, database access, exported workflows, screenshots, files, etc. Ideally in a format we can use and test ourselves.

2. Demonstration Video

Five to ten minutes sharing anything you think is relevant – for example, your solution running end-to-end and explaining any changes you made and why.

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Timeline

Finals Round

2nd of June 2026	Finalists notified
6th of June 2026 (11:59pm)	Finals submission deadline via email to dylan@padea.com.au
8th of June 2026	Finals presentation
10th of June 2026	Winners notified